Competency Exercise

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Western Michigan University

PADM 6001 Capstone Portfolio I

Dr. Mingus

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Competency Exercise

The Master of Public Administration (MPA) program at Western Michigan University (WMU) "…provides a foundation in the principles of administration, addresses the practical responsibilities of managers and leaders, and trains students for program management and policy analyses" (Western Michigan University, *Master of public administration* 2024). As a nationally-ranked Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs and Administration (NASPAA) accredited program, WMU's MPA program has been thoroughly assessed and deemed a program that emphasizes public services values, is mission-focused, and is designed to develop professionals in public and/or nonprofit affairs (NASPAA Accreditation Standards, 2023). One way for the MPA program to ensure compliance with program standards is through curriculum mapping through the use of a competency-based portfolio as outlined by Kapucu and Koliba (2017).

By creating the capstone portfolio, students will show their understanding throughout the five core competencies. The five competencies as outlined by the NASPAA are: (1) lead and manage in the public interest; (2) participate in, and contribute to, the policy process; (3) analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make evidence-informed decisions in a complex and dynamic environment; (4) articulate, apply, and advance a public service perspective; and (5) communicate and interact productively and in culturally responsive ways with a diverse and changing

workforce and society at large (2023). Each competency, often referred to as domains, will be addressed in this paper. Additionally the tentative MPA program plan will be submitted as Appendix A, which will give a direction of which courses to take and when in order to complete the program.

Domain One

To lead and manage in the public interest is to develop organizational standards and apply them appropriately. As a non-profit leader, it is vital to work in public interest while also maintaining the organization's mission and values. Identifying and applying key elements of the current strategic plan should also be a constant focus in when considering the growth and sustainability of an organization.

Domain Two

Participating and contributing to the policy process can be accomplished in a number of ways. Being able to interpret policy and analyze/propose policy alternatives is a crucial component of being a nonprofit leader. Keeping a finger on the pulse of implemented, passed, and proposed policies is a way in which leaders can protect and prepare their organizations for change. Developing and refining budgets, using stakeholder input to drive decision making, and using risk management solutions to be able to pivot with a changing political landscape are all examples that leadership can do to future proof.

Domain Three

To analyze, synthesize, think critically, solve problems and make evidence-informed decisions in a complex and dynamic environment is a role that an effective leader of an organization must take on. Not just navigating the system but consistently doing so with

best practices and making data-driven decisions is a key element to programmatic health. Public opinion may sway, which is why it is instrumental that an organization has a clear vision with consistent, not rash, decision making.

Domain Four

Being able to articulate, apply, and advance a public service perspective while keeping an intersectional mindset is a key component to effective leadership. Having an ethical responsibility, acting with integrity, and operating under a social equity scope are important factors when implementing a leadership approach. Being a responsible steward for fiduciary resources should be an upmost concern for nonprofit leadership. Distinguishing short-term from long-term fiscal consequences of policy making and programmatic changes should always be kept in consideration.

Domain Five

To communicate and interact productively and in culturally responsive ways with a diverse and changing workforce and society at large is a massive undertaking that should be developed and well planned. Proper communication can be the difference between a muddled statement or a succinct call to action. Leader’s lore isn’t born, it is defined one memo at a time.

Conclusion

Competency in all five domains will strike a balance between analyzing and implementation of policy, planning for short and long-term outcomes, and clearly communicating within the organization and community/stakeholders. A comprehensive portfolio will be worked on throughout the MPA program, adding individual assignments

to domain requirements from each course. While focusing on the program, it would also allow the opportunity to look at current professional areas of improvement while gathering data straight from the source. In-career professionals have a unique opportunity to develop and implement changes that were explored throughout the MPA program in real-time.

References

Master of public administration. Master of Public Administration | Western Michigan University. (n.d.). https://wmich.edu/spaa/academics/mpa

Network of Schools of Public Policy, Affairs, and Administration. (2023). *Accreditation Standards for Master's degree programs.* Retrieved from https://www.naspaa.org/accreditation/standards-and-guidance/official-standards-policy

Kapucu, N., & Koliba, C. (2017). Using Competency-based Portfolios as a Pedagogical Tool and Assessment Strategy in MPA Programs. *Journal of Public Affairs Education*, *23*(4), 993–1016. https://doi.org/10.1080/15236803.2017.12002301

Appendix A

MPA Program Plan (30-39 hours)
School of Public Affairs and Administration

Student Name: **Joshua Behymer**

Admission Date: _____ Pre/in-Career: **Pre-Career**

Advisor: Dr. Mingus Date Revised: _____

Expected Graduation: _____ Apply for Grad by: _____

Course #	Course Title	Req	Year	Semester/ Term	Credit Hours
Core Requirements (21 credits for Pre-Career or 18 for In-Career students)					
PADM 6000	Fundamentals & Ethics of Public Service	Y	2025	Fall	3
PADM 6001	Capstone Portfolio I	Y	2025	Spring	1
PADM 6010	Economic Principles for Public Service	Y	2026	Fall	3
PADM 6020	Public Policy & Politics	Y	2025	Spring	3
PADM 6060	Applied Research Methods	Y	2025	Fall	3
PADM 6070	Quantitative Data Analysis	Y	2026	Spring	3
PADM 6800	Capstone Portfolio II	Y	2027	Spring	2
PADM 7120	Professional Field Experience (for pre-career students only)	Y			3
Management Requirment (3 credit hours)					
PADM 6100	Public Service Management				3
PADM 6400	Managing Nonprofit Organizations	Y	2026	Fall	3
Human Resources Requirment (3 credit hours)					
PADM 5270	Human Resources Administration				3
PADM 6290	Leadership and Supervison	Y	2026	Summer II	3
Finance Requirment (3 credit hours)					
PADM 5120	Public Budgeting and Accounting				3
PADM 5420	Nonprofit Accounting and Finance	Y	2027	Spring	3
Elective (9 credits)					
PADM 5810	Social Entrepreneurship & Innovation				3
PADM 5825	Managing Community Growth & Development				3
PADM 5830	Grant Writing	Y	2025	Summer I	3
PADM 5840	Nonprofit Marketing and Development				3
PADM 5870	Fund Raising for Nonprofit Organizations				3
PADM 5880	Culture, Diversity, & Social Equity				3
PADM 5890	Strategic Planning & Performance Measurement				3
PADM 6301	Foundations of Federal Indian Policies				3
PADM 6302	Tribal Sovereignty through Self-Determination				3
PADM 6303	Tribal Economic Development & Diversification				3
PADM 6780	Program Evaluation				3
					3
					3
					3

Waiver(s) for students professional experience above and beyond in-career requirements, if applicable
(3 or 6 credit hours based on professional experience)

Note: 50+% of courses toward degree must be at 6000+ level.